

# 1 Thessalonians, Part 1

Acts 17:1-10; 1 Thessalonians 1-3 | *The gospel received under pressure*

**SERIES QUESTION** What problem is Paul addressing, and how does the gospel answer it?

**BIG IDEA** The gospel creates a faithful community whose changed life becomes a witness even under pressure.

## Follow the movement

| PASSAGE           | WHAT THE GOSPEL PRODUCES                                                                                                         |
|-------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Acts 17:1-10      | Jesus is proclaimed as the suffering, risen Messiah and King. Some believe; others oppose; the new church bears public pressure. |
| 1 Thessalonians 1 | Faith works, love labors, hope endures. Converts turn from idols, serve the living God, wait for Jesus, and become a witness.    |
| 1 Thessalonians 2 | The message is supported by lives free from manipulation and greed. Gospel workers share both God's good news and themselves.    |
| 1 Thessalonians 3 | Timothy strengthens the church. Their faith and love endure, and Paul prays for increasing love, holiness, and Christ's return.  |

## What makes faith visible

| 1 THESSALONIANS 1:3 | VISIBLE FRUIT                       |
|---------------------|-------------------------------------|
| Faith               | Work produced by trust in Christ    |
| Love                | Costly labor for the good of others |
| Hope                | Endurance rooted in Jesus Christ    |

## Conversion has direction

- TURN from idols to God
- SERVE the living and true God
- WAIT for his Son from heaven

## Look closer

**RANG OUT — 1:8** The Greek verb *exēcheomai* means to sound forth, echo, or resound. The Lord's message and the report of the Thessalonians' faith traveled far beyond their city.

**BLOCKED OUR WAY — 2:18** The verb *enkoptō* can picture a road being cut into or obstructed. Paul recognized spiritual opposition but did not tell the Thessalonians what earthly event Satan used.

## The message and the messenger

| PAUL REJECTS                                         | PAUL PRACTICES                                                             |
|------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Error, trickery, flattery, greed, and seeking praise | Courage, gentleness, honest work, encouragement, and sharing his life      |
| Using people for gain                                | Caring like a mother and encouraging like a father                         |
| Giving up when blocked                               | Sending Timothy, praying, writing, and continuing to strengthen the church |

## The Gospel Then and Now

**CHURCH REALITY THEN** A young church faced social pressure, political accusations, questions about Paul's motives, and separation from its teachers.

**CHURCH TEMPTATION NOW** We can measure health by buildings, budgets, attendance, programs, comfort, reputation, or "our kind of people" while overlooking faith, love, hope, holiness, and witness.

**GOSPEL-SHAPED CHURCH** God's Word works through the Holy Spirit, producing credible lives, costly love, steadfast hope, and a witness that resounds beyond the congregation.

### Discuss

1. What makes a church's faith in Christ visible?
2. Which signs of church health are easiest to confuse with gospel faithfulness?
3. How did Paul's conduct support his message?
4. What would it mean for the Lord's message to ring out from our congregation?

### For further study

**ECO CONNECTION** Essential Tenet III.B: election for salvation and service; III.C: covenant life in the church. [eco-pres.org/constitution/](http://eco-pres.org/constitution/)

**READ MORE ONLINE** BibleProject, Book of 1 Thessalonians Guide: [bibleproject.com/guides/book-of-1-thessalonians/](http://bibleproject.com/guides/book-of-1-thessalonians/)

#### CLASS RESOURCES & UPCOMING LESSONS

[keithbreuer615.github.io/pauls-letters-class/](http://keithbreuer615.github.io/pauls-letters-class/)



**BEFORE NEXT WEEK START HERE:** Read 1 Thessalonians 4:1–18 and 5:1–11. **CONTINUE IF POSSIBLE:** Finish chapter 5. Notice how believers live, grieve, wait, and encourage one another in hope.